

D269

Composition: Writing with a Strategy

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A clinic's office manager is writing a one-page handout that walks new patients through checking in on the online portal. She plans to print it on the clinic's blue letterhead and has three weeks before launch. What is the primary purpose of the handout?

- A. To inform: give clear steps for checking in.
- B. To promote the clinic's brand, since it is printed on letterhead.
- C. To persuade patients to choose this clinic.
- D. To express the manager's feelings about the new portal.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

An IT specialist is explaining a new password policy to warehouse staff who rarely use computers. He holds a network-security certification and wrote the policy's technical appendix. Which approach best fits the audience?

- A. Leave out all specifics so no one gets confused.
- B. Send the technical appendix as written, since accuracy matters most.
- C. Use technical terms throughout to sound credible.
- D. Use plain language, give concrete steps, and define any necessary terms.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A student writing for a sociology class that meets on Tuesday evenings drafts four possible thesis statements about remote work. Her instructor prefers APA style. Which is the strongest thesis?

- A. This essay will discuss remote work.
- B. Companies that offer hybrid schedules keep employees longer because workers gain flexibility without losing team connection.
- C. Remote work is always better than office work for everyone.
- D. In 2020, many employees began working from home.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which sentence is a statement of fact rather than a thesis?

- A.** Schools should start later because teenagers need more sleep.
- B.** Public libraries are the most important institution in any town.
- C.** The U.S. Census Bureau counts the population every ten years.
- D.** Cities should fund free public Wi-Fi because it narrows the digital divide.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A marketing coordinator finishes a draft proposal at 11 p.m. and plans to send it to a client in Denver. Rereading it the next morning, she sees that the second section does not support her main recommendation and needs to be reorganized and partly rewritten. Which stage of the writing process is she in?

- A.** Proofreading.
- B.** Editing at the sentence level.
- C.** Publishing, since it is going to a client.
- D.** Revising.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A writer is doing a final check of a finished report for typos, missing commas, and misspelled names. Which stage is this?

- A.** Drafting.
- B.** Revising.
- C.** Prewriting.
- D.** Proofreading.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A paragraph opens, The scheduling app cut overtime by 18 percent in six months. Later it includes one sentence about the app’s colorful icons and another about the CEO’s hometown. Which revision best improves the paragraph?

- A. Add transitions but keep every sentence.
- B. Move the topic sentence to the end.
- C. Remove the sentences about the icons and the CEO’s hometown.
- D. Round 18 percent up to 20 percent to make it easier to read.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A fundraising letter for a food bank states that the organization has operated for 25 years and is accredited by a national charity watchdog. The letter is printed on recycled paper and mailed in November. Which appeal does the accreditation statement mainly use?

- A. Ethos.
- B. Pathos.
- C. An appeal to timeliness, since it is mailed in November.
- D. Logos.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A writer wants to add a logos appeal to a proposal for a new protected bike lane. Which sentence does that?

- A. As a traffic engineer with fifteen years of experience, I recommend it.
- B. Streets with protected bike lanes in our county had 30 percent fewer cyclist injuries over five years.
- C. Imagine your child biking safely to school every morning.
- D. Every city that builds bike lanes eliminates all traffic deaths.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

Which revision puts this sentence in active voice? The quarterly budget was approved by the finance committee after a two-hour meeting in the east conference room.

- A. The two-hour meeting approved the quarterly budget.
- B. The quarterly budget had been approved by the finance committee.
- C. The finance committee approved the quarterly budget after a two-hour meeting.
- D. The quarterly budget approved the finance committee.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A team lead writes in a status email: The server migration finished at 3 a.m., the testing team starts at noon. The email went to twelve people on two continents. Which revision correctly fixes the error?

- A. The server migration finished at 3 a.m., however the testing team starts at noon.
- B. The server migration finished at 3 a.m.; the testing team starts at noon.
- C. The server migration finished at 3 a.m. the testing team starts at noon.
- D. Keep the sentence but send the email to fewer people.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which sentence is a comma splice?

- A. The printer jammed, we sent the file to the copy center.
- B. The printer jammed; we sent the file to the copy center.
- C. Because the printer jammed, we sent the file to the copy center.
- D. The printer jammed, so we sent the file to the copy center.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

A clinic's office manager is writing a one-page handout that walks new patients through checking in on the online portal. She plans to print it ~~on the clinic's blue letterhead and has three weeks before launch~~. What is the primary purpose of the handout?

Target word: primary purpose **Decides:** It walks patients through steps.

A	Correct	Step-by-step instructions inform the reader.
B	Camouflage	The paper does not decide the purpose.
C	Adjacent category	Nothing in the task asks readers to change a belief or choice.
D	Confusion set	Expressive writing centers on the writer, not the reader's task.

2. Answer D Concept 2

An IT specialist is explaining a new password policy to warehouse staff who rarely use computers. ~~He holds a network security certification and wrote the policy's technical appendix~~. Which approach best fits the audience?

Target word: fit to audience **Decides:** Readers rarely use computers.

A	Absolute language	Readers still need the steps to comply.
B	Camouflage	His expertise and appendix do not decide what this audience needs.
C	Adjacent category	Credibility matters, but jargon blocks understanding for this audience.
D	Correct	Matches what these readers know and need to do.

3. Answer B Concept 3

A student writing for a sociology class ~~that meets on Tuesday evenings~~ drafts four possible thesis statements about remote work. ~~Her instructor prefers APA style~~. Which is the strongest thesis?

Target word: strongest thesis **Decides:** Specific, arguable claim with a reason.

A	Dropped element	Announces a topic but makes no claim.
B	Correct	Specific, debatable, and gives a reason.
C	Absolute language	Too sweeping to support.
D	Adjacent category	A fact, not an arguable position.

4. Answer C Concept 3 • transfer

Which sentence is a statement of fact rather than a thesis?

Target word: spot the fact — reverse of picking the thesis **Decides:** Verifiable and not arguable.

A	Confusion set	Also a debatable claim, not a fact.
B	Absolute language	An opinion stated in sweeping terms, not a fact.
C	Correct	Verifiable fact; no one argues it.
D	Inverted operation	An arguable claim with a reason: a thesis.

5. Answer D Concept 4

A marketing coordinator finishes a draft proposal ~~at 11 p.m. and plans to send it to a client in Denver.~~ Rereading it the next morning, she sees that the second section does not support her main recommendation and needs to be reorganized and partly rewritten. Which stage of the writing process is she in?

Target word: name the stage **Decides:** Reorganizing and rewriting content.

A	Confusion set	Proofreading fixes typos and surface errors.
B	Adjacent category	Editing polishes sentences, not section structure.
C	Camouflage	Who receives it does not decide the stage.
D	Correct	Changing content and organization is revision.

6. Answer D Concept 4 • transfer

A writer is doing a final check of a finished report for typos, missing commas, and misspelled names. Which stage is this?

Target word: name the stage from surface work **Decides:** Surface errors, last pass.

A	Adjacent category	Drafting produces the text; this is checking it.
B	Inverted operation	Revising is big-picture content work, the opposite end.
C	Confusion set	Prewriting is planning before any draft.
D	Correct	Final surface-error check.

7. Answer C Concept 5

A paragraph opens, The scheduling app ~~cut overtime by 18 percent in six months.~~ Later it includes one sentence about the app's colorful icons and another about the CEO's hometown. Which revision best improves the paragraph?

Target word: fix the paragraph **Decides:** Two sentences do not support the topic sentence.

A	Dropped element	Transitions cannot fix sentences that are off topic.
B	Adjacent category	Position is not the problem; unrelated content is.
C	Correct	Restores unity: every sentence supports the topic.
D	Wrong stem number	Changes accurate data and does not fix unity.

8. Answer A Concept 6

A fundraising letter for a food bank states that the organization has operated for 25 years and is accredited by a national charity watchdog. ~~The letter is printed on recycled paper and mailed in November.~~ Which appeal does the accreditation statement mainly use?

Target word: name the appeal **Decides:** Accreditation and history build credibility.

A	Correct	Track record and accreditation build trust in the writer.
B	Confusion set	Pathos targets emotion; accreditation targets trust.
C	Camouflage	Mailing month does not describe the accreditation sentence.
D	Confusion set	Logos is evidence and reasoning about the claim.

9. Answer B Concept 6 • transfer

A writer wants to add a logos appeal to a proposal for a new protected bike lane. Which sentence does that?

Target word: produce logos — reverse of classifying **Decides:** Evidence-based reasoning.

A	Adjacent category	Credentials: ethos.
B	Correct	Data supporting the claim is logos.
C	Confusion set	Emotional image: pathos.
D	Absolute language	An overclaim, not sound reasoning.

10. Answer C Concept 7

Which revision puts this sentence in active voice? The quarterly budget was approved by the finance committee ~~after a two-hour meeting in the east conference room.~~

Target word: active-voice revision **Decides:** The committee must become the subject doing the approving.

A	Camouflage	Makes the meeting detail the actor; the committee approved it.
B	Adjacent category	Changes tense but is still passive.
C	Correct	The actor is now the subject.
D	Inverted operation	Swaps the roles and changes the meaning.

11. Answer B Concept 8

A team lead writes in a status email: The server migration finished at 3 a.m., the testing team starts at noon. ~~The email went to twelve people on two continents.~~ Which revision correctly fixes the error?

Target word: fix the splice **Decides:** Two independent clauses joined by a comma alone.

A	Adjacent category	“However” is not a coordinating conjunction; this is still a splice.
B	Correct	A semicolon correctly joins two independent clauses.
C	Dropped element	Removing the comma creates a fused sentence.
D	Camouflage	The recipient list does not decide the grammar.

12. Answer A Concept 8 • transfer

Which sentence is a comma splice?

Target word: spot the error — reverse of fixing it **Decides:** Two independent clauses, comma only.

A	Correct	Two full sentences joined by a comma alone.
B	Adjacent category	The semicolon version is the fix, not the error.
C	Confusion set	A dependent clause plus a comma is correct.
D	Inverted operation	Comma plus “so” is correct.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	10	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	4	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	8	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	6	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Purpose drives the document	Decide whether the main purpose is to inform, persuade, or express before choosing content and form.	Letting format or branding decide the purpose.	“What is the primary purpose?”
2	Audience analysis	Match vocabulary, detail, and structure to what the reader already knows and needs to do.	Writing for the writer’s expertise instead of the reader’s.	An expert writing for non-experts, or the reverse.
3	A strong thesis	A thesis is a specific, arguable claim with a reason; it is not a topic announcement or a plain fact.	Accepting “This essay will discuss...” or a statistic as a thesis.	“Which is the strongest thesis?”
4	Revise, edit, proofread	Revising changes content and organization; editing improves sentences and word choice; proofreading fixes surface errors last.	Treating typo checks as revision.	Big-picture changes vs. sentence changes vs. typos.
5	Paragraph unity	Every sentence in a paragraph should support its topic sentence.	Fixing unity problems with transitions alone.	A paragraph with a sentence that drifts off topic.
6	Ethos, pathos, logos	Ethos appeals to credibility, pathos to emotion, and logos to evidence and reasoning.	Calling any statistic pathos or any expert claim logos.	Credentials (ethos), feelings (pathos), data (logos).
7	Active voice	In active voice the subject does the action; it is usually clearer and shorter than passive voice.	Thinking a tense change or word swap makes a sentence active.	“was [verb]ed by” in the original sentence.
8	Comma splices	Two independent clauses cannot be joined by a comma alone; use a period, a semicolon, or a comma plus a coordinating conjunction.	Fixing a splice with “however” and a comma, or deleting the comma.	Two complete sentences joined by only a comma.

Course scope (public description): Welcome to Composition: Writing with a Strategy! In this course, you will focus on three main topics: understanding purpose, context, and audience, writing strategies and techniques, and editing and revising. In addition, the first section, will offer review on core elements of the writing process, cross-cultural communication, as well as working with words and common standards and practices. Each section includes learning opportunities through readings, videos, audio, and other relevant resources. Assessment activities with feedback also provide opportunities to check your learning, practice, and show how well you understand course content. Because the course is self-paced, you may move through the material as quickly or as slowly as you need to gain proficiency in the seven competencies that will be covered in the final assessment. If you have no prior knowledge or experience, you can expect to spend 30-40 hours on the course content.